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PHOTOGRAPHY

PHOTOGRAPHY: Concepts, Technicalities, Photo Analysis, and Critical Viewing Skills

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I. Introduction

"Photography is the story I fail to put into words." — Destin Sparks

In a world saturated with visual content, photography has become one of the most powerful forms of communication. Every scroll through social media, every news headline, every family album tells a story through images. But how many of us truly understand what goes into making a photograph or how to critically read one?

Photography is far more than pointing a camera and pressing a button. It is a deliberate art and science that combines technical knowledge, creative vision, and cultural awareness. This paper explores the general concepts and technicalities of photography, examines how photographs can be analyzed, and develops the critical viewing skills necessary to look beyond the surface of an image.

II. Background/Context

Key Terms and Concepts

To understand photography, one must first be familiar with its foundational vocabulary:

- **Photography:** from the Greek phos (light) and graphé (drawing); literally "drawing with light." It is the process of capturing light onto a photosensitive surface to produce an image.
- **Exposure:** the amount of light that reaches the camera sensor or film, controlled by three elements: aperture, shutter speed, and ISO.
- **Aperture:** The lens diaphragm (measured in f-stops) that regulates light volume and Depth of Field.
- **Shutter Speed:** the length of time the camera's shutter remains open. A fast shutter speed (e.g., 1/1000s) freezes motion; a slow shutter speed (e.g., 1/30s) creates motion blur.
- **ISO:** the camera sensor's sensitivity to light. Low ISO (100–400) produces clean images in bright conditions; high ISO (1600+) is used in low light but introduces "noise" or grain.
- **Composition:** the arrangement of visual elements within a frame. Common techniques include the Rule of Thirds, leading lines, symmetry, and framing.
- **Depth of Field (DOF):** the range of distance in a photo that appears acceptably sharp.



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- **White Balance:** the adjustment of colors to make the image look natural under different lighting conditions (e.g., sunlight, fluorescent, candlelight).
- **Frame:** the boundaries of the photographic image; what is included and excluded.

The Exposure Triangle

The three pillars of proper exposure — aperture, shutter speed, and ISO — are collectively known as the Exposure Triangle. They work together in balance: changing one requires adjusting the others to maintain the correct exposure. For example, shooting in a dark room might require a wide aperture (f/1.8), a slow shutter speed (1/60s), and a high ISO (1600) to achieve a properly lit image.

Brief Historical Context

Modern photography emerged in 1839 with the daguerreotype, succeeding centuries of experimentation with the *camera obscura*. The technology progressed from volatile glass plates to flexible film, culminating in the 21st-century digital revolution that democratized the craft for a global audience.

Ethical Dilemma in Photography

Photography carries ethical weight. Photographers must consider issues such as:

- **Consent** — photographing people, especially in private or vulnerable situations, raises questions of privacy.
- **Manipulation** — digital editing tools like Photoshop can alter reality, raising concerns about deception, especially in photojournalism.
- **Representation** — how subjects are photographed can reinforce or challenge stereotypes, affecting how communities are perceived.

Key Stakeholders

- **Photographers** — the creators who make technical and artistic decisions
- **Subjects** — the people, places, or objects being photographed
- **Viewers/Audience** — those who interpret and assign meaning to images
- **Media organizations** — outlets that publish and contextualize photographs
- **Educators** — those who teach visual literacy and critical viewing



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III. Argument/Analysis

Position

Photography is not a passive medium — it is a deliberate act of storytelling that requires both technical mastery and ethical responsibility. Understanding the technicalities of photography empowers both creators and viewers to engage more meaningfully with images.

Supporting Evidence

Technical decisions are inherently narrative. For instance, a wide-angle perspective of a protest emphasizes collective scale, whereas a telephoto close-up prioritizes individual pathos. While both depictions are factually accurate, the framing dictates the viewer's perceived reality. Furthermore, visual literacy is a vital 21st-century skill; the National Council of Teachers of English (NCTE) indicates that trained viewers are less susceptible to media manipulation. This necessity is underscored by the 2023 surge in viral, AI-generated images that successfully deceived the public, highlighting the urgency of critical viewing in modern media consumption.

Counterarguments and Rebuttal

Critics contend that photography is merely a technical aptitude and that rigorous analysis diminishes a work's emotional resonance. However, this perspective overlooks the deliberate nature of the craft. Even 'instinctive' captures are filtered through the creator's cultural lens and personal bias. Rather than stripping an image of its power, critical analysis enriches the viewing experience by uncovering the complex layers of meaning embedded within the frame.

IV. Ethical Analysis

Utilitarianism

From a utilitarian perspective, photography that serves the public good — such as documentary photography that exposes injustice or raises awareness of social issues — is ethically justified. The greatest good for the greatest number supports the use of photography as a tool for social change, even when the images are uncomfortable or disturbing.



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Deontology

Deontology prioritizes moral duty and rigid adherence to rules, mandating that photographers always obtain informed consent and avoid deceptive manipulation. Under this framework, the act of altering images to mislead the public is inherently unethical, regardless of any potential positive outcome.

Virtue Ethics

Virtue ethics asks: what would a person of good character do? A virtuous photographer exercises honesty, empathy, and respect — choosing angles and moments that represent their subjects with dignity, and being transparent about the nature and context of their images.

V. Activity

“Picture This!”

Instructions:

1. The class will be divided into **5 groups** by counting off from 1 to 5.
2. Each group will select **one (1) representative** who will go outside the classroom to take a photo of anything that represents a photography concept discussed in the lesson.
3. The representative has **5 minutes only** to go outside and return to the classroom. Punctuality is part of the grading.
4. Once the representative returns, the whole group has **3 minutes** to collaborate and come up with a **sentence or definition** that explains what photography concept their photo represents.
5. The group will then choose **one (1) presenter** (can be the same representative or a different member) to present the photo and their group's definition to the class.
6. The presenter has **1 minute only** to present. Stay within the time limit.



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Rubrics

Criteria	4 – Excellent	3 – Proficient	2 – Developing	1 – Beginning	Score
Timeliness (Representative returns within 5 mins)	Returns with 1+ min to spare	Returns exactly on time	Returns 1–2 mins late	Returns more than 2 mins late	/4
Relevance of Photo	Photo clearly and creatively connects to a photography concept	Photo connects to a concept with minor ambiguity	Photo loosely relates to any concept	Photo has no clear connection to the lesson	/4
Definition/Sentence Quality	Clear, accurate, and uses proper photography terminology	Mostly accurate with minor errors	Partially correct but vague or incomplete	Inaccurate or off-topic	/4
Presentation Delivery	Confident, clear, and within the 1-minute limit	Clear delivery but slightly over/under time	Somewhat unclear or noticeably over time	Inaudible, incomplete, or greatly over time	/4
Teamwork & Collaboration	All members actively participated in crafting the definition; group was clearly organized	Most members contributed; minimal confusion during the 3-minute discussion	Only a few members were visibly engaged; some disorganization	Only one member worked; group appeared uninvolved or unprepared	/4
				TOTAL:	20 points

VI. Conclusion

Photography is a sophisticated language articulated through light, composition, and perspective, requiring a meaningful engagement with both its technical foundations and underlying intent. From the mechanics of exposure to the weight of ethical responsibility, the medium challenges the observer to look beyond the surface and see the world with critical depth. Given this complexity, developing analytical viewing skills in a visually-driven society is an essential defense against misinformation; by questioning the origin and purpose of an image, viewers transform from passive consumers into informed interpreters of visual culture.

Every image serves as a silent invitation to pause and look again. What is the world truly revealing to you?



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